

GETTY IMAGES



Sponsored by Kingfisher for Rs 12 crore a year, a post-match cocktail of cricketers, sponsors, fashion designers and creatures called 'celebrities'. Photos of the players with women of unidentified significance are now making it regularly to Page 3.

What's NEW

The ultimate interruption earns IPL Rs 54 crore a year. Never before seen in the history of cricket TV, the IPL has made space and time for advertisements in between overs. They are shown on the stadium screen and through it on TV.

ADS DURING OVERS



GETTY IMAGES



The super-luxury spot where shoulders are rubbed with shiny people after paying for five-figure tickets. Delhi Daredevils set up a stand, offered limo pickups, tickets, food, drinks, party access and sold 200 tickets at Rs 40,000 each. The KKR's IPL Club Lounge cost Rs 32,000.

THE MARQUEE

MORE IN SEASON FOUR

**TEAMS FROM 8 TO 10
MATCHES FROM 60 TO 94
DURATION 54 DAYS**

End of the icon All 'icons', superstar cricketers, are in the common wash again. The 15 per cent salary hike given to them in the first auction in early 2008 will end. Franchises can retain four Indians and three overseas players but must offer them fat wages.

Total salary cap The world's single largest sports auction with a total salary cap of Rs 35 crore (\$7 million) per franchise will be held this year. In 2008, the cap was Rs 20 crore. Pune and Kochi are expected to lure big ticket players with high salaries.

Rotating roster No one can play more than 14 matches, the number they do now, in order to prevent burn-out. With 10 teams scrambling for at least 25 players each, unknown domestic Indian cricketers will be desperately sought.

Breakthroughs Selling of space on the purple and orange caps for Rs 12-15 crore each, and the development of new media rights using 3G technology takes off.

New stadia Pune's new ground, 'once the Mercedes Benz of Indian cricket grounds,' should be up and running by March 2011. Kochi says the Nehru Stadium, where its ODIs are held, is the second largest after Eden Gardens. It is being returfed and roofed.

Modi, the man with the most famous lisp in India, has also become its most audacious money maker. Show him an empty space and he will hang a logo on it. Give him free airtime and he will sell it. Heck, point out a piece of the sky and he will monetise it. The biggest names in world cricket are walking billboards, some sporting as many as seven logos (eight, if you count title sponsor DLF). Modi has made another Rs 54 crore by selling 150 seconds of airtime on SetMax by carrying ads on the scoreboard during an over. Why, even the air above a stadium can be sold: after all, it costs MRF Rs 15 crore to have its blimp in the sky for 24 matches.

New on-ground sponsorships for the strategic time-out and a new central sponsor give teams additional earnings from the central revenue pool. Last year the pool was restricted to broadcasting rights (Rs 67.5 crore for each team). Now with Internet rights, theatrical screenings in bars, after-match parties Colors' IPL-related programming (see box) cricket and entertainment are stretched to breaking point.

The world, it appears, is not enough for Modi, who was reportedly disappointed when he was unable to sell the rights for the orange and purple caps worn by the IPL's leading run-scorer and wicket-taker, being pitched separately to brands at Rs 15 crore a year each.

The total worth of the IPL industry today is estimated at \$4 billion, according to a Brand Finance study of what it calls the event's 'eco-system.' It was SetMax's capitulation last year that gave rise to the new numbers. In a tense battle that reached the court, Modi asked Sony to raise its \$1 billion rights ownership of the IPL to \$1.6 billion. Sony raised the revenue it earned from advertising on Season 1 (Rs 450 crore) to Rs 700 crore by opening up sub-categories to competing brands.

It was possible because the ratings remained steady, allowing Sony to charge Rs 4-5 lakh per 10 seconds, (top soaps charge Rs 1.5 lakh per 10 seconds). According to Television